

bill, and know that everything any financial institution does for you costs something, somewhere.

But the best way to understand the punitive nature of interest rates and fees is to see them at work. I accidentally stumbled onto a concrete way to demonstrate how painful it is to lose a big portion of my money in fees when I took my son, Trevor, to try out one of those green coin counters at the local grocery store a couple of years ago. We have something we call the Money Bowl. Over the years, whenever we have loose change in our pockets, we put it in the Money Bowl. So a while ago, I noticed that the massive bowl was getting quite full. I was pretty sure we had about \$500 just sitting there, and I thought this would be a great project to get Trevor involved in. Counting out all that change by hand would have taken ages, so Trevor and I headed to the local grocery store with the Money Bowl. I had heard that these machines quickly counted the coins and issued a receipt that you took to the checker in exchange for the cash in bills. All you had to do was drop the coins in a tray and let the machine do the rest. So that's what we did. Fistful by fistful, we dropped coins into a tray while the machine tallied everything up. After about twenty minutes of doing this, the Money Bowl was empty. Great! Job completed. But it wasn't until the machine spat out a receipt that I realized it had charged us a whopping 9.8 percent "counting fee." I couldn't believe my eyes. To say I was furious is an understatement.

"Dad, what's wrong?" Trevor asked, picking up on the expression of shock that was writ large across my face.

"I can't believe this," I said. And then I explained to my son that we'd been had.

"But that's totally unfair!" was his response. "We have to fight this."

So, knowing that I hadn't read the fine print on the machine before inserting our coins, I decided to fight the fees. I complained to the manager, my son standing next to me.

"I just paid a big green machine almost \$50 to count coins for me," I said. "My son would have done it for \$10."

"Yup," the manager said. "Buyer beware."

"So you can't lower the fee at all?" I asked. "That's robbery!"